2008 and this would make India's GDP growth numbers comparable with that of developed nations.

The base year was also shifted from 2004–05 to 2011–12. The MoSPI stated that shifting the base year to 2011–12 would enable the inclusion of many sectors such as IT, e-commerce, mobile telephony, etc., not included earlier, and this would provide a more realistic and representative picture. The new 2011–12 series would take into account the population census (2011), agriculture census (2010–11) and livestock census (2012), and incorporate the results of the most recent National Sample Surveys.[7]

In a significant change, instead of using data from the Annual Survey of Industries (comprising approximately two lakh factories) to gauge activity in the manufacturing sector, the annual accounts of companies filed with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, the MCA21, started to be used. As the MCA database covered almost five lakh companies, this was considered a more reliable indicator of corporate activity.

The happy outcome of this change in methodology was that it lifted India's growth rate for 2013–14 to 6.9 per cent instead of the 4.7 per cent earlier estimated! Similarly, for FY 2016–17, GDP estimates were projected at 7.6 per cent based on the new GVA methodology.

Though there were many who criticized this as a 'sleight of hand', in fairness, the changes were reasonable ones. However, what makes it a legerdemain is the fact that the previous GDP estimates were not recast on these bases, making comparators or trend analysis extremely difficult. This effectively meant apples were being compared to oranges.

In August 2018, the National Statistical Commission released a back-series calculation of data for comparative purposes that showed double-digit growth under the former UPA government. The government swiftly refuted this data stating that the back series were not 'official estimates'.